

Food Chains & Ecosystems

Use the cue, then fade the cue. Study the cue card for 60 seconds. Then cover it before answering Round 1. Check the card only after you commit to an answer.

CUE FOCUS Energy flows from the **Sun** to **producers** (plants), then to **consumers** (animals that eat), and **decomposers** break down dead things. In a food chain the arrows point toward the eater—the way energy flows. A **food web** is many chains linked together, and living things depend on one another.

Round 1 — Retrieve It

1. Where does the energy in a food chain begin?

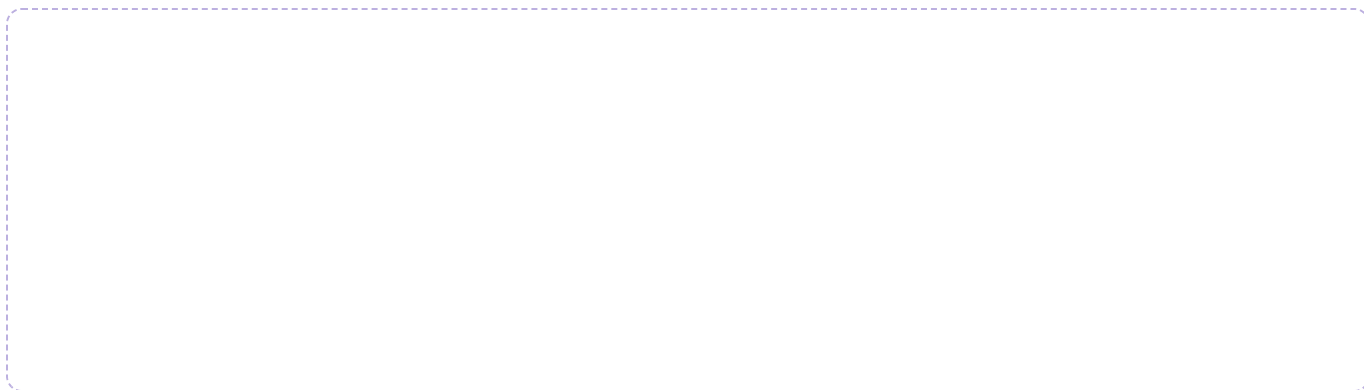
2. What is a producer? Give one example.

3. What do decomposers do?

4. In a food chain, which way do the arrows point?

Round 2 — Sketch It

Draw a food chain with at least three living things. Start with the Sun and use arrows that point toward the eater to show which way the energy flows.



Food Chains & Ecosystems — Apply It

Keep the cue card covered. Answer first. Then use the cue to check, revise, and explain what you changed.

Round 3 — Apply the Idea

1. In the chain grass → rabbit → fox, which living thing is the producer, and where did its energy come from?

2. A mushroom grows on a fallen log and helps it rot away. What is the mushroom's job in the ecosystem called?

3. You draw an arrow from a caterpillar to a bird. What does that arrow tell you about who eats whom and how energy flows?

Round 4 — Reason from Evidence

In a food web, the plants suddenly die off. Explain what could happen to the consumers, and use this to describe how living things depend on one another.

Food Chains & Ecosystems — ACE It

Use the cue card only if you need it. The goal is to show what you can explain, connect, and use on your own.

A**Articulate**

Explain how energy flows through a food chain, from the Sun all the way to a consumer. Use the words producer and consumer.

C**Connect**

Explain the difference between a food chain and a food web, and tell why a food web shows how living things depend on one another.

E**Extend**

Build your own food web with a producer, two consumers, and a decomposer. Draw the arrows the correct way and explain one connection.

Confidence check. Circle one after you finish: I still need the cue / I need it once in a while / I can explain this without it.

Teacher Key — Food Chains & Ecosystems

Remove this page before student copying. Answers below give expected ideas, not required wording.

Retrieve It

1. With the Sun (the Sun's energy is the start of the food chain).
2. A producer makes its own food, such as a plant (grass, a tree, algae).
3. Decomposers break down dead plants and animals (example: mushrooms, bacteria, worms).
4. Toward the eater—the direction the energy flows.

Sketch It — look for

A chain of three or more living things starting with the Sun, with arrows pointing toward the eater (energy flowing from producer to consumer).

Apply It

1. The grass is the producer; its energy came from the Sun.
2. It is a decomposer (its job is breaking down dead things).
3. The arrow shows the bird eats the caterpillar; energy flows from the caterpillar to the bird (arrows point toward the eater).

Reason from Evidence — look for

If the plants (producers) die, the consumers that eat them lose their food and could go hungry or die, and animals that eat those consumers are affected too. This shows living things depend on one another.

ACE — Extend look-for

A food web with a producer, two consumers, and a decomposer; arrows point toward the eater, and the student explains at least one correct energy connection.

Suggested use. Run Page 1 with the cue card available, Page 2 with the cue mostly covered, and Page 3 as independent reflection. Let students uncover the cue to self-correct in a different color.